

20th-century fashion

At the beginning of the 20th century, fashion choices were limited, with most people in a region wearing similar styles. But over the decades, fashion became more free. This was partly because improved travel gave designers access to styles from around the world. By the late 20th century, people were able to choose from a wide variety of fashion trends.

Colonial style

Sapeurs

Where Congo

When 1930s

The arrival of French colonizers in Congo gave rise to the sapeur (“dressed up”) culture. Local Congolese adapted French styles, such as three-piece suits and silk socks, to challenge the supposed superiority of the colonists by emulating their clothing in an extravagant way. Sapeur style has seen a revival in the modern day.



Wrapped around

Cheongsam



Where Shanghai, China

When 1920s

This high-necked, close-fitting dress (also known as qipao) is believed to have evolved from styles of the Qing era (see pp.140–141).

It was made popular by upper-class women in Shanghai, and came to be associated with the rise of the modern Chinese woman.

Postwar fashion

Dior's New Look



Where Paris, France

When 1940s

French designer Christian Dior's first clothing collection, the “New Look” was launched in 1947. It featured dresses with rounded shoulders, narrow waists, and full skirts. The style became fashionable in the years following World War II, as it was different from the functional clothing of the war period.

Snazzy formalwear

Zoot suit

Where US

When 1940s

This baggy suit style with shoulder pads and flared pants was inspired by the suits worn in dance halls in the 1930s. Zoot suits were popularized by Mexican- and Black American men from working class neighborhoods across the US, and went on to influence suit styles for decades.

